

THE HILLS ARE ALIVE

From the highest trek in Karnataka to an offbeat wildlife experience in Kerala, here's how to make the most of your next hill station vacation in South India

By Prachi Joshi

Remember the hill station holidays of your childhood? Languid walks, promenading on Mall Road, stuffing your face with fudgy 'chocolate, perhaps a boat ride on the lake. As nostalgic as that sounds, the new-age traveller holidays differently—whether it's chasing experiences, embarking on thrilling treks or visiting historical sites. If you're planning a summer vacation in the picturesque hill stations of southern India, here's a curated list of unmissable experiences.

Nilgiri Mountain Railway

For the most scenic train journey

Built by the British in 1908, the Nilgiri Mountain Railway offers a ride like no other. The scenic 46-km railway links the plains at Mettupalayam with the hill stations of Coonoor and Udagamandalam (Ooty). It is the only one of its kind in Asia, operating on metre-gauge 'rack and pinion' traction as it negotiates a steep gradient. It is also one of only two rail routes in India that still uses steam-powered engines. On its way, the charming blue train (colloquially called 'toy train') chugs through steep mountains and dense forests, passing through 16 tunnels and over 250 bridges. In July 2005, UNESCO declared the Nilgiri Mountain Railway a World Heritage Site under the 'Mountain Railways of India'.